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From the editor-in-chief

Indians have had a rough time since September 2008 when the global recession hit us where it hurt the most: the job market. There were brutal job losses across sectors, with exports, finances, textiles, automobiles and the BPO-KPO business the worst hit. Employers held back on recruitment and the salaries of those lucky enough to hold on to their jobs were slashed.

Now whatever else is happening in the rest of the world, here in India, we can all breathe a bit more easy. This year has seen an increase in spending and, with it, demand, a trend that will only have a positive domino effect. It is estimated that in the next three years, corporate India will invest \$250 billion and over the next year close to a million new jobs could be added. These are great numbers for 2010-2011. We have arrived at them as part of our annual INDIA TODAY Ma-Foi Employment Trends Survey. The survey reaches 1,000 companies of all sizes based all over India in a range of sectors from manufacturing, finance, hospitality and retail among others. This year's results are optimistic. India's GDP is expected to grow between 7 and 7.5 per cent and is estimated to touch 8.5 per cent in 2010-11 from a low of 6.7 per cent in 2008-09. It is this increase that has led to this surge in new jobs.

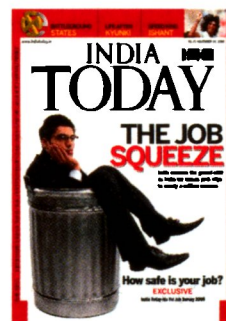
The sectors expected to witness the most significant increase in new jobs are health, hospitality, infotech, realty and education. In many ways this is a reflection of middle India's demands for better medical facilities, housing and an improvement in schools and colleges. As a result, investment is being pumped in to make up for the shortage. The boom in the job market does not merely benefit India Inc though. The health sector, which employs people across the class spectrum, is regarded as the one that will offer more jobs than any other, nearly three lakh in a year.

Despite the meltdown, India did well during and after the financial crisis. That was mostly due to a surge of demand in the rural economy, the Government's new initiatives and higher procurement prices combined with what is called the pay commission effect. Indeed as early as May 2009, we had announced "Hope is Back" and declared the worst was over. The rebound in the economy is now an accepted fact. Industrial growth has risen in the last two quarters. The rural market has been the biggest buffer and the automobile and consumer durables industry will offer at least 68,000 new jobs in the next year. Even though there will definitely be a demand for high-end white goods, many companies now understand that their most viable and regular consumers are to be found in hundreds of India's villages.

Our cover story this week combines the employment trends with an analysis of the Budget and was put together by Managing Editor Shankkar Aiyar with Senior Editor Malini Bhupta focussing on the survey.

It has to be said that all the good news has come from the private sector. India Inc had gone the distance to re-start a flagging economy, so expecting a budget of big bang reforms was not just wishful thinking. What the Government gave us instead was an incremental, virtual status quo budget. Like someone said, it had more revision and less vision. India's job market must escalate to keep its economy on its projected growth path. It can only do so with a genuine private-public partnership. To use a baseball phrase, it is time now for the Government to step on to the plate and hit some home runs for the economy.

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)



OUR NOVEMBER
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